



Course report for AG2500 Spring term 2025

The 2025 IAGG thesis course registered 42 students, of which 14 were reregistered students from previous years who had not yet completed their thesis, and 28 were from the graduating cohort. 3 additional students wrote their thesis at Fudan, within the framework of the double degree program. Of the 42 enrolled students, 30 completed their thesis (either in May or September 2025, or February 2026). The grade distribution was 8 High Pass and 22 Pass. The remaining students have either not submitted or were encouraged to withdraw their thesis, continue revising and resubmit at a later submission opportunity.

The course had the same structure as in previous years. Two rounds of preparatory seminars are held in December and January, and there are three opportunities to submit per year: in May, September and February.

In terms of examination, theses are screened and if significant problems are detected, students are encouraged to withdraw the thesis, to continue working and to resubmit at a later point in time. Each thesis is then evaluated by a main and secondary examiner, discussed at a seminar by both a student discussant and the main examiner, and then discussed at a meeting with all the examiners after the seminars. Students then receive written comments in a grading sheet, which also indicates the grade.

In an effort to reduce uncertainty regarding finding a supervisor, the course guide was revised to better explain the process. The course guide was also revised to clarify the following points:

- The screening process (some students had not understood it would take place),
- That grades are not posted directly after the seminar but rather after a week.
- More detail on what distinguishes a Pass from a High Pass.
- Clearer statement of the word count limit
- The necessary components of a good thesis, e.g. what the methods section needs to cover, the role of a theoretical framework, the importance of attention to alternative explanations, the importance of discussing the limitations in one's own data and analysis.
- Information about what is a reasonable number of meetings with a supervisor and how to best structure the work: Plan the goals and time for the next meeting.

In 2025, only 10 students completed the course evaluation. It is difficult to convince students to complete the evaluation of the course since those that submit have either completed their studies, and those that do not submit are not in a position to respond to the questionnaire.

The table below shows responses on questions regarding the course overall, supervision, the two rounds of preparatory seminars held in December and January to provide preliminary feedback on their proposed topic, design and methods, the examination seminars and the organization of the course overall.

	Course overall	Supervision	Preparatory seminars	Examination seminars	Course organization
Very good	4	6	2	2	4
Rather good	4	2	4	6	3
Neither good nor bad	2	2	3	1	2
Rather bad	0	0	1	1	1
Very bad	0	0	0	0	0

Student evaluations were on the whole positive, with 8 out of 10 responding rather or very good on almost all points. That one person felt the preparatory and examination seminars, as well as the course organization, were 'rather bad' is of course cause for concern. These critical responses were unfortunately not explained in the open-ended follow-up questions provided.

The course evaluation also asked about their own work effort and the extent to which they found the course demanding. Most felt the requirements to be reasonable, while some felt they were somewhat too high or too low. That said, only one person reported spending more than 40 hours per week on the course.

Much too demanding	0 (0.0%)
Somewhat too demanding	3 (30.0%)
OK	5 (50.0%)
Not that demanding	2 (20.0%)
Not at all demanding	0 (0.0%)

Less than 10 hours	2 (20.0%)
11-20 hours	1 (10.0%)
21-30 hours	2 (20.0%)
31-40 hours	4 (40.0%)
More than 40 hours	1 (10.0%)

The course evaluation also asked whether they had experienced discrimination in any form during their time in the program, and no such incidents were reported.

Finally, the evaluation asked which methods course they had attended and whether they felt it provided the training required to complete the thesis. As the student attend one of three methods courses, there were very few responses on each course. A few responded that the methods courses were helpful while others felt they were not more in-depth than the training they'd received at the bachelor's level.